

County Council Budget Hearings 2025, Wednesday September 3rd Morning Session

Meeting Metadata	Details
Video Recording	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=YgOM0g9MKyw
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Delaware County Council Budget Hearings: Meeting Summary Report

Meeting Date: (Implicitly Day 1 of Annual Budget Hearings)

Location: Delaware County Council Chambers

Report Purpose: A comprehensive, accessible summary of municipal proceedings for community members, local journalists, and policy researchers.

1. Pre-Meeting Hearings & Committee Work Sessions

(Note: A statutory public hearing was held immediately prior to the regular budget hearing session.)

- **Session Type & Topic:** 00:00:05 Statutory Public Hearing on the Delaware County Annual Budget and Tax Rates.
- **Summary of Discussion:**
 - The floor was opened for public testimony regarding the upcoming county budget.
 - Council members and staff addressed general financial realities, noting that the county faces a projected revenue shortfall requiring approximately \$7.4 million in

budget cuts for the upcoming 2026 budget cycle. Officials pointed to stagnant property tax levy growth, increasing circuit breaker tax caps, and legislative changes (such as Senate Bill 1) as contributing factors to long-term structural deficits.

2. Meeting Identification & Attendance

- **Call to Order & Spoken Details:** 00:09:14 The budget hearings were formally called to order by the presiding officer.
 - **Attendance:**
 - **Members Present:** All council members were present and accounted for (noted by Ben at 00:09:56).
 - **Presiding Officer:** Identified via context as the Council President / presiding chair.
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3. Preliminary & Procedural Business

- **Ceremonial Openings:** 00:09:15 The meeting opened with the Pledge of Allegiance, led by Jessica.
 - **Approval of Prior Minutes:** *(Not addressed during this portion of the transcript.)*
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4. Substantive Business & Board Action

(Departmental budget reviews and revenue discussions conducted chronologically through the morning session.)

A. Auditor & General Financial Overview

- **Presenter:** Tanya (Auditor) & Elizabeth / Whitney (Financial Staff).
- **Deliberation Summary:**
 - Staff highlighted that the county must cut roughly \$7.4 million from the 2026 general budget requests (\$46.49 million requested vs. ~\$38.1 million projected revenue) to maintain a healthy operating balance.
 - Council established a preliminary strategy to **freeze salaries at 2025 levels** across departments to help close the gap.
- **Action & Disposition:** Informational review; consensus reached to apply 2025 salary baselines for preliminary modeling.

B. Information Technology (IT) Budgets

- 00:17:45 IT Department & Data Processing Budgets (Jim Fluke / Jim's Corp)

- **Presenter:** Jim Fluke.
- **Deliberation Summary:** Discussed contractual service costs, hardware/software maintenance cycles, and long-term cloud migration strategies (Google/Microsoft products) to mitigate rising physical server replacement costs. Jim returned \$40,000 intended for VMware software increases that were ultimately unnecessary.
- **Action & Disposition:** Reviewed and adjusted.

C. Purdue Extension Office

- **00:27:44 Purdue Extension Budget (Pages 30 / 15)**
 - **Presenter:** Justin Curley & Molly Hunt (Area Director).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Clarified funding split between federal (Smith Lever), state, and county general contributions. Highlighted educational and health-related programming (diabetes, nutrition, 4-H youth development) and noted difficulties in securing external grants due to federal/state reductions. Justin Curley corrected an administrative error on an office manager salary line (-\$1,066 adjustment).
 - **Action & Disposition:** Salary and operating line items adjusted to 2025 levels.

D. County Treasurer

- **00:44:00 Treasurer's Office Budget (Pages 1 / 9)**
 - **Presenter:** Brad (County Treasurer).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Reported positive news regarding investment income, projecting over \$3 million in investment revenue for 2025 (surpassing initial \$2 million estimates). Addressed increases in printing and postage lines mandated by commissioners for tax statement mailings. Discussed potential vendor changes (L&D Mailers vs. Master's Touch) to reduce mailing costs.
 - **Action & Disposition:** Reviewed; adjustments made to professional services and dues lines.

E. County Surveyor & Drainage Board

- **02:11:19 Surveyor's Office & Corner Perpetuation Fund (Pages 14 & 75)**
 - **Presenter:** Tom (County Surveyor).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Discussed vehicle maintenance, fuel costs, and the statutory requirement to locate 5% of county cornerstones annually via licensed land surveyors (\$20,000 contractual cap). Addressed drainage board postage requirements for certified mailings on ditch reconstructions.
 - **Action & Disposition:** Adjusted and aligned with Corner Perpetuation fund allocations.

F. County Assessor

- **02:06:45 Assessor's Office & Reassessment Funds (Pages 17 & 80)**
 - **Presenter:** James Hughes (County Assessor).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Reviewed staff levels (noting no staff growth since 1999 despite dropping from 39 municipal assessors to a centralized county office). Discussed level two and three statutory staff certification pay lines and postage line corrections.
 - **Action & Disposition:** Reviewed and adjusted.

G. County Recorder

- **02:29:59 Recorder's Office & Perpetuation Funds (Pages 3 & 72 / 57)**
 - **Presenter:** Jan (County Recorder) & Deputy.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Discussed record preservation projects, historical book binding costs (\$4,800<U+2013>\$5,000 per book), part-time staffing needs for back-indexing digital images, and property fraud alert successes in partnership with local law enforcement.
 - **Action & Disposition:** Reviewed and adjusted.

H. Delaware-Muncie Metropolitan Planning Commission (MPC)

- **02:59:05 Planning Commission Budget (Page 31)**
 - **Presenter:** Kylene Swaim.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Highlighted that the department generates federal and permit fee reimbursements covering approximately 120% of its salary costs. Noted a newly executed interlocal agreement with the City of Muncie/Redevelopment Commission providing \$25,000 annually for two years toward the executive director's salary. Discussed reductions across minor operating lines.
 - **Action & Disposition:** Reviewed and adjusted.

I. County Coroner

- **03:22:04 Coroner's Office Budget (Page 16)**
 - **Presenter:** Gavin Green (County Coroner).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Reported an increase in caseloads (454 cases projected/tracked compared to previous years). Addressed rising contractual autopsy costs (\$1,850 per autopsy via pathologist contract, totaling roughly \$259,000 annually) and increased travel/DNA testing expenses.
 - **Action & Disposition:** Contractual services adjusted to \$270,000; operating lines adjusted to 2025 levels.

J. Tourism & Visitors Bureau (Destination Muncie)

- **03:42:38 Tourism Commission Budget (Page 49)**

- **Presenter:** Jared Walls (President) & Treasurer.
- **Deliberation Summary:** Presented the annual contractual request funded entirely through the Innkeeper's Tax (self-sustaining). Noted upcoming hotel openings (Holiday Inn Express, Home2 Suites, and a Hilton Tapestry Collection) which will drive future innkeeper tax revenues.
- **Action & Disposition:** Reviewed.

K. Fair Board & Expo Center

- **03:54:10 Fair Board Budget (Page 87)**
 - **Presenter:** Melanie Marshall & Carrie Dye.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Discussed minor increases in utility, liability insurance, and workers' compensation lines. Noted the successful community night at the fair underwritten by Destination Muncie. A detailed and complex discussion ensued regarding the employment status and health insurance coverage of the fair office secretary, prompting further review by the commissioners and council.
 - **Action & Disposition:** Reviewed.

L. GIS / Mapping Department

- **03:57:27 GIS Department Budget (Page 25)**
 - **Presenter:** Kyle.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Kyle presented a flat budget (with a \$100 increase in office supplies) and advocated for adding a new full-time GIS specialist position. Officials discussed the critical integration of GIS into public safety (CAD systems, emergency services) and noted that the new position could absorb municipal live-streaming duties to offset external vendor costs.
 - **Action & Disposition:** Position request retained in the preliminary budget for further evaluation.

5. Open Public Comment / Citizen Forum

- **00:00:33 Rick Yanser (Newsman and Author):** Spoke during the initial public hearing. Expressed concern over the lack of a readily available printed agenda, cautioned against property and income tax increases amid rising costs of living, and requested public records access for budget documents.

6. Administrative Updates & Adjournment

- **Staff / Board Announcements:** **04:13:50** The presiding officer announced a recess for lunch, instructing attendees and council members to return in approximately one hour.

- **Adjournment:** 04:13:53 Meeting recessed for lunch (Approved by Voice Vote).

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